

**THE
SPEEDY APPEARANCE
OF
CHRIST
DESIRED BY THE CHURCH**

by

John Church

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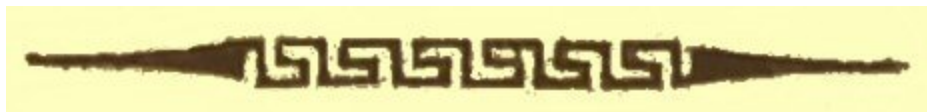
BEING THE SUBSTANCE OF A

Sermon,

PREACHED ON THE DEATH OF A FRIEND,

August 27, 1815.

BY J. CHURCH,
MINISTER OF THE GOSPEL, SURREY TABERNACLE.



It shall be said in that day, lo, we have waited for him, he will save
us.—*Isaiah* xxv, 9.

Even so come, LORD JESUS—*Rev.* xxii, 20.

Southwark:

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A SERMON.

SOL. SONG, 8th Chap. last Verse.

*Make haste, my Beloved, and be thou like to a Roe, or a young
Hart upon the Mountains of Spices.*

THIS divine Poem, is designed by the Holy Spirit, to exhibit the love of God our dear Saviour, to his chosen people, with all the happy consequences of that eternal affection. The whole book is full of Christ, as the all in all of the Church, which he has purchased with his blood—the union subsisting between the elect head and chosen body. What Christ is to them, and they are to him, is strikingly set forth by many well-known metaphors. Perhaps there is nothing of greater importance in the Bible than the Union subsisting between Jesus and his Church, the whole Scriptures are full of it; all our salvation depends upon it. The highest idea of Union is that glorious oneness in the three Persons the adorable Trinity; that though they are distinct in Persons, Names and Offices, yet they are one in the divine incomprehensible Essence.

The next idea of Union is the hypostatical Union of God in our Nature: the Word made Flesh and dwelling among us. This is the mystery of Godliness. The Union between the head and members is the principal subject of this Song. That Christ and his People are one, is an everlasting truth, the date of it is eternal, it is indissolvable, it is mysterious, it is perfect, and will endure to all eternity. Hence it is compared to the Union that subsists between the foundation of a building and its superstructure. Christ is the foundation stone, the corner stone, the tried stone, and will be the top stone.

This Union is set forth by the metaphor of the head and the body, while the love that united both is set forth in this song, by the neck. The self-moving love of God will keep this body and head in eternal Union. This is also

represented by the Vine and the Branches. *I am the Vine, ye are the Branches.* All our fruit depends on Union with this Vine—*In me is thy fruit found.* The scriptures shew this doctrine by the Union that subsists between the Husband and his Wife: this says the Apostle *is a great mystery; but I speak concerning Christ and his Church.*

In consequence of this Union with Christ and his People, they become partakers of the same Spirit with him. He that is joined to the Lord is one spirit. He took our nature, we take his spirit, and like the men of Judah, we have two parts in David. We are bone of bone, and flesh of his flesh; and the Apostle tells us, *we are members of his body, of his flesh, and of his bones.* Christ being united to his Church, beholds it with admiration; highly commends her, and to shew how dear she is to him, he laid down his life for her, in the set time, to favor our souls. He subdues our enmity, melts our hearts, reconciles our wills, draws our affections to himself, and leads our faith to admire him, believe in him, rest on him, and be satisfied with him. He loves us, we love him; he chose us, we chuse him; he is delighted in us, we in him; he sought us, we seek him; he commands us, we commend him; he draws near to us, we draw near to him; he loves the company of his people, they desire his; he invites them to his arms, his house, his table, and to holy familiarity with him. His people seeing his glory, beauty, suitableness, and love, intreat him to visit them, to meet them, to abide with them, to be in them, walk with them, talk with them, and indulge them with his company. Thus the Union is mutual, and sweet communion is the blessed effect of it. The Saviour must see of the travail of his soul, in their complete conversion. He longs for their coming home, and they long to get home to see him, who is the brightness of the Father's glory, and the express image of his Person. Under this sweet influence of the spirit of love, the Church breathes forth her earnest desires—*Make haste my beloved, and be thou like to a Roe, or a young Hart upon the mountains of spices.*

The first petition in this song is for clear manifestations of his love. *Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth.* And the last petition is the language of the text, the earnest desire to see his face. This is the Alpha and Omega of the Spirit's teaching.

We shall first consider the object desired.—*My beloved.*

Secondly, Her earnest request, *Make haste*. And thirdly, The metaphor here made use of, *Be thou like a Roe, or a young Hart upon the mountains of spices*.

First—The glorious object of the desire of every one taught of God, emphatically stiled *My beloved*. This title is given to Jesus, nineteen or twenty times in this book; and no doubt is intended to point out the high esteem the church has of her Saviour; the clearest, the sweetest evidence of a person's interest in Christ, is love to the dear God-Man Mediator. This principle is shed abroad in the heart; it is always in the believer as a principle; but it is not always shed abroad in the feeling sense of it, we wish it was, as it is calculated carry us above the love of sin, the love of self, the love of the creature, and the love of the world. Christ as the Christ of God, is the darling of heaven; the Father loves him, and is well pleased with him. The Holy Spirit's principal aim in all his operations is to glorify him; the holy angels admire and adore him, as their elect head; the spirits of just men, made perfect, look on him with holy wonder, with rapture, and joy; while every poor, tried, humble believer, trusts in him, leans upon him, hopes in him, and sincerely desires to love him above all things else. And if I know any thing of experience, I must say in the behalf of the church, it is our principal grief we think on him so little, trust him so little, admire and adore him so little. This is a lamentation, and must be so to the end of our days. But our days of mourning on this subject will have an end—and

Till then I would thy love proclaim,
With every feeling breath;
And may the music of thy name,
Refresh my soul in death.

Christ is the beloved of his church for what is in himself, as God-Man Mediator. Secondly, Christ is beloved of his church for what he has done, and is now doing in heaven. If we view him as God, possessing all divine perfections, and these harmonizing and engaged in our salvation, O! how glorious do they all appear! Divine sovereignty chose us to salvation; loved moved him to make this choice; wisdom drew the wonderful plan; power executed it; goodness made provision for us; truth makes us free; faithfulness is engaged to make good his promises; pity redeemed us; compassion leads us to repentance; holiness makes him all-glorious to us;

righteousness justifies; justice forgives us; and perfection renders us compleat in Christ. Thus all his sublime attributes center in our salvation, and render Jesus as equal with the Father, beloved to us, if we view him as Man and Mediator. *There is*, says the Apostle to us, *One God and one Mediator, the Man*, (i.e. *the God Man*) *Christ Jesus*. In this human nature he is the perfection of beauty; the Holy Spirit formed it, the Father provided it, and the eternal Son of God appeared in it as our Day's Man. It was filled with the Holy Ghost—it was a sacred Temple, the residence of Deity. *The word was made flesh—the word was God*. All things were made by him. This human nature was holy, harmless, undefiled, and separated from sinners; and such an High Priest became us. And by virtue of the Union of the Godhead; this dear God-Man is the Beloved of the whole Church.

If we consider him in his Mediatorial capacity, sustaining his glorious offices, as Prophet, Priest, and King. These offices no doubt he refers to when he said I am the way, and the truth, and the life; to these he was called. These he executes in the church, and in the hearts of all believers. He enlightens us as a Prophet, he intercedes as a Priest, and he reigns as a King. He teaches the way to heaven as a Prophet, he opens the way as a Priest, and he brings into the way as a King. He preached glad tidings to the meek as a Prophet, he binds up the broken-hearted as a Priest, and he opens the prison doors as a king. These glorious offices he exercises in the souls of his children, and viwing him faithful in his house, he is truly lovely to his church. If we view him in his glorious titles, it appears the Holy Ghost has ransacked all the endearing ties of nature, and all the lovely instances of his creative power, to set him forth—the affectionate Husband, the constant Friend, the skilful Physician, the tender Father, the able Counsellor, the sympathizing Mother and Nurse, the wise Law-giver, the lovely Prince, the faithful Ambassador, and the Advocate with the Father; the guide of his Children, and the Captain of their salvation. He is represented as a Lamb, a Hen, a Hind; surely

All over glorious is our Lord;
To be admir'd, and yet ador'd:
His worth if all the nations knew,
Sure the whole earth would love him too.

The operations of his hands as the adorable Creator, sets him forth in his goodness, greatness, and glory—the earth is full of his praise—

He shines in the sun, refreshes in the breeze,
Glowes in the stars, and blossoms in the trees.

Every drop of dew, every shower of rain, every blade of grass, every rolling peal of thunder, and every flash of lightning, loudly proclaims the eternal power and Godhead of him who lived, and loved, and died for us. The word of the eternal truth, the Scriptures, are an exhibition of his loving heart. Its histories, types, shadows, and parables—all the illustrious characters that appeared before him were only as dim stars, to usher in the glorious luminary, the Light of Life. Every promise, invitation, and declaration, all, all! proclaim the Beloved. O for hearts to love him more, and serve him without reserve, and to long to be with him, that we may behold his glory for ever.

But, Secondly, The Request made for his speedy appearance, *Make hast my beloved; be thou like a Roe, or young Hart upon the mountains of spices.* This may include in it the earnest wish of the Old Testament saints for the Incarnation of Jesus; it had been long foretold, and it was expected by all the saints, though nearly four thousand years rolled away before their desires were accomplished. The dear Messiah made his appearance at last, to put away sin, to honor the Law, to satisfy Justice, to glorify the attributes of Deity, bar the mouth of the bottomless Pit, and open the gates of the celestial City. How beautiful the language of the Church, (TE DEUM) *When thou tookest upon thee to deliver man thou didst not abhor the Virgin's womb. When thou hadst overcome the sharpness of death, thou dist open the kingdom of heaven to all Believers.* This was the subject matter of the faith of Old Testament saints. This important God-glorifying event, they anticipated, and though millions of the elect died without the sight, they all died in faith, embracing the promises, and Jesus in them.

This Chapter opens and closes with their ardent wish, *O that thou wert as my brother, that sucked the breasts of my mother! Make haste my Beloved.* When Believers, on any occasion, pray thus, we are not to suppose they wish for the blessing before the time, though in fact, as the Saviour said on another occasion, Your time is always ready. But there is a time for every

purpose, a set time, and Christ came in the fulness of time, nor will he delay one blessing laid up for his people beyond the time. Faith is always willing to wait God's time, but unbelief is always in a hurry, *He that hasteth with his feet sinneth—he that believeth shall not make haste.*

Secondly, The Request may be considered as made by the Church of God in the depths of trouble, when storms of fierce persecution has involved her, or awful errors abounding and carrying away many professors; and such has been the case of the Church frequently: this may be seen clearly in the state of the Gospel Church, as stated in the 12th of the Revelations. Blessed be God, in the worst times, there have been a few praying souls, who have been concerned for the glory of the Redeemer, the cause of truth, and the welfare of Zion. Such have united their petitions for the delivery of Zion, and obtained an answer, as Moses did, *I have seen the afflictions of my people, and I am come down to deliver them.* And as the Psalmist also obtained the blessed answer, *For the oppression of the poor, and the sighing of the needy, now will I arise, saith the Lord.*

Thirdly, This Request for the coming of Jesus, may be considered as the language of a soul in straits and difficulties. Hence, some have exclaimed, *Make haste to help me, O my God, make no long tarrying.* The burden of guilt, the power of unbelief, the temptation of the enemy, the frowns of the world, the loss of all that is near and dear, the fears of being lost at last, that what has been experienced is but the attainments of an hypocrite; and at the same time, amidst all these things there is to be found the *one good thing toward the Lord God of Israel*, an inward breathing after Jesus, a thirsting for the living God—a desire to be delivered in God's way, either by an open manifestation of Christ to the soul, or a strengthening, faith-encouraging hope, applying a promise or melting the soul in the flames of eternal love. A kind hint, a love-token, or a sweet view of Jesus afresh.—Hence the argument of the church of old, *Wilt thou not revive us again, that we may rejoice in thee? Make haste therefore, my beloved.*

Fourthly, This Request may be considered as the church's desire for the manifestative presence of Christ; nothing, perhaps, can exceed this New Covenant promise, *I will dwell with them.*—Surely with rapture and surprise we must ask, *And will God in very deed dwell with men on the earth?* Stupendous condescension! infinite grace and love!

Stand in amaze ye rolling skies,

The presence of Jesus is life and peace—it softens the hard cares of life, sanctifies humble poverty; makes obedience easy; trials sweet; ordinances precious; and eternity desirable. The presence of Jesus endears the blessings of providence; adds a glory to creation, and causes the earth to be filled with his praise. This gives a relish to the bounties of nature; adds a double beauty to flowers, and a double sweetness to fruits.

This Request may be considered as the language of the whole Church, longing for the second coming of Jesus Christ. It is clearly revealed that the Lord will appear again the second time, without spot and sin, to salvation; the brightest display of history, and the complete Deliverer of his people. It is necessary he should appear again—the consummation of the Marriage Union is an event our dear Lord must accomplish, when he will leave the third heavens, and descend into the air with his heavenly retinue, to meet his Bride complete, body and soul, upon her resurrection from the dead. O what a joyful meeting of the heavenly Bridegroom and the spiritual Bride, of the glorious company of saints and angels, of the body and souls of God's children, to sin no more, to sorrow no more, but to be like Jesus, see his face, enjoy his smiles, and so be for ever with the Lord. The thought is animating—Come, Lord Jesus, come quickly! *Make haste, my beloved*—the event will be awful, but glorious, the procession such as never has taken place in the upper or lower worlds. Perhaps some things are said about it, in allusion to earthly processions when a judge enters a town. O when the stars fall, when the sun hides his head, when the moon is confounded, when the world is in a blaze, then, then! O gracious Saviour, own us in that day for thine; and he surely will, O believers, as you have been enabled to own him in the midst of a crooked and perverse generation; as sure as you are born again of the spirit, love him in soul, cleave to him in faith and hope, depend on him for life and salvation, and love all his gracious appearances. The crown is laid up for them who love his appearance.—This leads us to notice the metaphor here made use of, *a Roe or a young Hart upon the mountains of spices*. This is a phrase frequently used in this Song; and sometimes Christ is compared to these lovely creatures, no doubt, for their loving natures, excellent and choice, for the antipathy between them and serpents—for their thirst, after the conflict they usually have with Serpents: they are also remarkable for longevity, but in this text are mentioned to

shew their remarkable swiftness of foot: their speediness is used to set forth the swiftness of Christ to the soul, over mountains of sorrow, hills of grief, over all the difficulties that are in the way. The request, then, is simply thus, Make haste my beloved, and fly swift to me, as a Roe or Hart upon mountains, where they delight to run and skip: so his gracious presence is desired on the mountains of Zion, the congregations of the saints, and the hearth and families of believers. The celebrated Dr. *Gill* thinks these mountains refer to the glory beyond the grave: the height and sublimity of this happy state; it is above, reserved in heaven—a hope, a crown laid up, the prize of the high calling—it is a permanency, an everlasting joy—pleasures for evermore!

O ye blest scenes of permanent delight!
Full without measure, lasting without bounds!
A perpetuity of bliss is bliss.

I trust our dear friend and Brother is now in the enjoyment of this unspeakable felicity; to this all the people of God were predestinated by the Father—for this they were redeemed by Jesus—for this they are called by the Holy Spirit, made partakers of a divine nature and preserved unto this kingdom and glory. This inheritance is sure to all the seed; but there must be a preparation for it, a calling out of the world, a good hope through grace; the pardon of sin, and a receiving the righteousness of God our Saviour. There must be a knowledge of Jesus, union to him and communion with him; this is our meetness for glory; and however uncandid it may be deemed, I am bold to affirm, that no man can behold the face of God with joy, without those blessings in time. Hear this

Ye opposers, transgressors of every degree,
And formal professors, the worst of the three.

As it respects our departed Friend, it appears he had lived in nature's darkness, sin, and misery, like the rest of mankind, till about a year ago, when it pleased the Lord to lead him to hear the Gospel as preached by unworthy me. I believe the passage I had occasion at that time to discourse on was, *Look not upon me because I am black, because the sun hath looked on me*. I rather suppose his convictions began about this time; the word laid hold of his heart; he saw himself a lost sinner, justly condemned by the

Law, which he soon found to be spiritual, that it cursed him for a sinful thought as well as sinful works. The fears of death, the guilt of sin, the suggestions of Satan, and the dread of judgment and eternity, were all felt by him.—He found himself shut up in unbelief, and neither might or power of his own could extricate him.—He was at the same time sadly tried in circumstances, so that the hand of God seemed to go out against him in every direction. But that most blessed Spirit of all grace, who had taken possession of his soul, and given him light to see and life to feel himself a sinner, also begot in him a living hope, that he should be delivered. The Holy Spirit convinced him of unbelief, and at the same time operated on his mind as a spirit of faith. He convinced him of his carnal enmity, yet operated as a spirit of love.

Thus the blessed Spirit generally deals with his dear people. Our Brother, amidst all he felt, attended constantly on the word—and he that waiteth on his Master shall be honored, and so he found it.

The glorious Gospel exhibits the eternal love of the Father, the freeness of divine grace, and the pardon of the vilest, through the blood of the Lamb. These immortal truths, accompanied by the power of the Spirit, begot in his mind a pleasing hope of salvation. Love operated in his heart as faith was led to eye the Saviour, and by waiting on the Lord his faith grew strong in the doctrines of the Cross, so that he gradually experienced the joys of salvation, which did not leave him, but for a season, till his dissolution.

Through a variety of trials and wants his health began rapidly to decline, and soon baffled the use of medicine: but as the body was thus gravitating to its own center, the dust, his soul was happy in a good hope, through grace, the love of God, and the precious Person of Jesus.

When confined to his bed I had occasion to visit him often, and generally found him happy. I must confess I staggered a little at his felicity, but I knew the Holy Spirit was a Sovereign, and had a right to do as he pleased. But I apprized our Friend, that I doubted whether he would go quite so easy to heaven, without a cloud, without an assault, without a temptation: not but he was deeply afflicted in his body; and it is the mercy of God's elect to experience this grand truth, *He stayeth his rough wind in the day of the East wind.*—In a few days time my prediction of his troubles came to pass. He

was tried and tempted indeed. His body getting worse, Satan took occasion from some trying circumstances which occurred, to distress his mind, which absolutely deprived him of his rationality for some few days and nights, with very few intervals of sanity. But while in this afflicted state Prayer was made for him constantly among us, and by the kindness of the Church, especially the younger brethren, who were assiduous in their attention to him, we had the happiness of seeing him restored, and once more composed, and happy in Jesus. But the time drew near that he must die: the Lord dealt very graciously with him in that solemn period, for which we have much cause to be thankful.

On the Lord's-day morning of his death, he was visited by many godly characters. He looked around on them all, and thanked them for their kind attention to him and his family. When it was intimated they should soon see each other in glory, he smiled, and said, *I shall be so taken up with Jesus, I shall not be able to think much of any one else.* He now appeared to be dying upward, but spoke of it without dismay; being wearied he desired to be once more turned in his bed. He dosed a little while; when well awoke, he exclaimed, *Christ is all in all!* He paused; then earnestly said *Blessed Jesus, hast thou not promised I shall be with thee? and thou canst not be worse than thy word.* He paused again, then cried out, *He has done all things well.* Then he said again, *Thou dear Redeemer, dying Lamb, I love to hear of thee.* At three in the afternoon he seemed to be sinking in the arms of death, and solemnly said to a friend, *I am getting nearer.*—Then he said soon after, *I am very near—I am quite close*—(to his eternal home he meant). At about the close of the day after, having laid some time quiet, he exclaimed, *Come Lord, come Lord Jesus, come quickly! Come Lord, come!—He is come, he is come! I come, I come!* His voice gradually fell, but as long as his lips could move, his friends could hear him say, *Come, come, come!* With these words he dropt asleep in the arms of our blessed Lord—to whom be glory.

AMEN.

FINIS.

Thomas, Printer, Red Lion Street, Borough.

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE SPEEDY
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